CHAPTER 15

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS IN INDIAN POLITICS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:

Examine the five transformative developments shaping contemporary Indian politics since 1989: the decisive end of Congress dominance and dawn of the Coalition Era, the implementation of the Mandal Commission recommendations reserving jobs for Other Backward Classes, structural economic liberalisation under the 1991 New Economic Policy, the rise of Hindutva and Mandir-Masjid politics culminating in the Babri Masjid demolition, and the emergence of broad national coalitions including the NDA and UPA leading to contemporary political consensus.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **The End of Congress Dominance and Coalition Era:** The 1989 general elections ended single-party hegemony, initiating a multi-party coalition era where no single party secured an absolute majority until 2014, making regional parties decisive power brokers.

• **Mandal Politics and OBC Empowerment:** Prime Minister V.P. Singh's decision in August 1990 to implement the Mandal Commission recommendation of 27 percent reservations for Other Backward Classes in central government jobs revolutionized Indian politics, mobilizing backward caste voters.

• **Structural Economic Liberalisation (1991):** Confronting a severe balance of payments crisis in 1991, the P.V. Narasimha Rao government launched structural adjustment reforms (Liberalisation, Privatisation, Globalisation), fundamentally altering state intervention doctrines.

• **Consensus in Contemporary Indian Politics:** Despite sharp party competition, four broad consensuses emerged: agreement on new economic reforms, acceptance of social and political claims of backward castes, acceptance of the national role of state parties, and pragmatic ideology over dogmatism.

ESSENTIAL CONSTITUTIONAL ARTICLES & THEORIES

$$\text{1990s Transition Matrix} \iff \{\text{End of Congress Dominance}, \quad \text{Mandal Reservations}, \quad \text{1991 LPG Reforms}\}$$

Three Structural Catalysts of Contemporary Indian Polity

$$\text{Mandal Commission (1980)} \iff \text{27\% Central Job Reservation for OBCs} \rightarrow \text{Implemented 1990 (V.P. Singh)}$$

Statutory Affirmative Action Empowering Backward Castes

$$\text{Coalition Evolution} \iff \text{National Front (1989)} \longrightarrow \text{United Front (1996)} \longrightarrow \text{NDA (1998)} \longrightarrow \text{UPA (2004)}$$

Chronological Trajectory of National Coalition Formations

$$\text{Consensus in Indian Politics} \iff \text{Economic Reforms} + \text{OBC Political Assertion} + \text{State-Level Alliances} + \text{Pragmatism}$$

Four Broad Pillars of Shared Governance Convergence

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Remember that the Mandal Commission was appointed by the Morarji Desai Janata Party government in 1978 and submitted its report in 1980; it was implemented a decade later in 1990 by V.P. Singh's National Front government.

• **Alert:** Do not state that the Coalition Era ended multiparty democracy; in fact, the Coalition Era dramatically broadened Indian federalism by giving regional state parties ministerial representation at the Centre.

• **Alert:** Avoid writing that economic reforms of 1991 were abandoned by subsequent governments; every subsequent government (United Front, NDA, UPA) continued and deepened the economic reform agenda.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Which General Election marked the end of the 'Congress System' of single-party dominance in Indian politics? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **General Election:** The Ninth General Election held in November 1989. **[1 Mark]**

• **Significance:** Congress was defeated, and no single national party gained an absolute majority, inaugurating an era of multi-party coalition governments at the Centre that lasted for twenty-five years. **[1 Mark]**

2. Who headed the Second Backward Classes Commission and what was its most controversial recommendation implemented in 1990? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Head of Commission:** B.P. Mandal (Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal), appointed in 1978. **[1 Mark]**

• **Controversial Recommendation:** Recommended 27 percent reservation in central government jobs and educational institutions for Other Backward Classes (OBCs), implemented by Prime Minister V.P. Singh in August 1990. **[1 Mark]**

3. Outline three major developments in Indian politics that took place during the crucial decade of the 1990s. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **End of One-Party Dominance and Coalition Politics:** Began with the National Front government in 1989 supported from the outside by both the Left Front and the BJP. **[1 Mark]**

• **Implementation of Mandal Report:** Sparked intense student protests, legal battles (Indira Sawhney case), and transformed political mobilization around backward caste identities. **[1 Mark]**

• **Structural Economic Reforms of 1991:** Shifted India from an inward-looking socialist model to an open market economy through deregulation, privatization, and foreign direct investment. **[1 Mark]**

4. Explain how the implementation of the Mandal Commission recommendations transformed the social composition of Indian politics. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Rise of Backward Caste Leadership:** Galvanized backward caste identity, enabling regional leaders and parties (such as Samajwadi Party, Rashtriya Janata Dal, and JD(U)) to capture power in northern India. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Deepening of Democratic Representation:** Shifted political power away from upper-caste urban elites, ensuring that OBC communities attained substantial representation in state assemblies and Parliament. **[1.5 Marks]**

5. Describe the economic context that prompted India to initiate structural economic reforms in 1991. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Acute Balance of Payments Crisis:** Foreign exchange reserves plummeted to under one billion dollars in 1991, barely sufficient to finance two weeks of essential imports like petroleum. **[1 Mark]**

• **Severe Fiscal Deficit and Inflation:** High public debt, fiscal deficits, and double-digit inflation severely strained the domestic economy. **[1 Mark]**

• **New Economic Policy:** Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh dismantled the license-permit raj, lowered tariffs, and opened key sectors to foreign private investment. **[1 Mark]**

6. Trace the evolution of national coalition alliances in India from the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) to the United Progressive Alliance (UPA). [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **National Democratic Alliance (NDA, 1998 to 2004):** Formed under the leadership of Atal Bihari Vajpayee, bringing together the BJP and numerous regional parties based on a National Agenda for Governance, successfully completing a full five-year term (1999 to 2004). **[1 Mark]**

• **United Progressive Alliance (UPA, 2004 to 2014):** Led by the Congress under Sonia Gandhi with Dr. Manmohan Singh as Prime Minister, governed for a decade supported by regional allies and outside support from the Left Front. **[1 Mark]**

• **Empowerment of Regional Parties:** Federal coalition alliances gave state-level parties unprecedented leverage over national policymaking, portfolios, and budget distributions. **[1 Mark]**

• **Post-2014 Paradigm:** The 2014 and 2019 elections restored a single-party majority for the BJP in the Lok Sabha, yet governance continues within the overarching framework of the NDA coalition. **[1 Mark]**

7. Highlight the four elements of consensus that have emerged across major political parties in contemporary Indian politics. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Consensus on New Economic Policies:** All major parties agree on the continuation of economic reforms, liberalization, and trade integration, believing it generates prosperity. **[1 Mark]**

• **Acceptance of Backward Caste Claims:** Broad political consensus on affirmative action, educational reservations, and political empowerment of OBC communities. **[1 Mark]**

• **Acceptance of Regional Parties in Governance:** Recognition that regional parties represent authentic federal aspirations and are indispensable partners in national governance. **[1 Mark]**

• **Pragmatic Power-Sharing:** A shift from dogmatic ideological confrontation to pragmatic alliance-building and governance focus based on shared minimum programmes. **[1 Mark]**